

Between: Easing the Fear of Death Through Peaceful Play

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Figure 1: *Between* is an independent game about death and loss, where players explore past lives in an atmospheric graveyard. The game is available at <https://xiaocrstn.itch.io/inbetweendeathgame>, with the trailer accessible at <https://youtu.be/lpG84BSszQo>.

Abstract

With the aim of helping to ease the fear of death, our game *Between* communicates a peaceful atmosphere surrounding death and loss. In the game, players explore a digital graveyard and interact with gravestones by typing the names of the deceased. Each name is accompanied by a string of melodies and flower petals reflecting personal traits. The designer's fear of loss toward her own mother motivated this project, and throughout the development, the fear was greatly eased. We aim to communicate this transformative effect to a broader audience with similar fears—those who may not have experienced a close loss yet but share the concern. The game seeks to connect these individuals, share the fear of death, and eventually provide comfort.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → HCI theory, concepts and models.

Keywords

Loss, Death, Transformative, Game design, Death-themed games, Digital mourning

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1 Introduction

Death is an essential part of our lives and cultures. In this work, we examine the game *Between* as a transformative medium to ease the fear of death—both the fear of one's own death and the fear of losing loved ones. *Between* aims to create a beautiful and soothing atmosphere around death, expressing the theme that death is merely a phase of life that encourages us to cherish the limited time and companionship we have. The game is also the first part of a doctoral dissertation, through which we aim to explore and digitize three diverse mourning cultures via game design. Consequently, the game is expected to be followed by a series of games featuring graveyards from different cultures.

Our game fits into the genre of existing games that explore the topic of grief and permanent death. These games are often referred to as death-themed games, and some have been examined as tools for aiding death education or helping individuals cope with grief in real life [10, 18, 25]. However, most of these games focus on expressing grief after loss, with few addressing the fear of death before loss. Our game is aimed at individuals who may not have experienced a close loss yet but are beginning to realize that death and separation may occur someday. The game *Between* seeks to express peaceful and neutral attitudes toward death, help connect these individuals, share the fear of death, and eventually provide comfort.

In death studies and psychology, there are established studies on the measurements, degrees, and treatments for the fear of death before loss. However, few have integrated these with interactive media, such as game design. In this work, we do not delve deeply into psychology nor claim any therapeutic effects from the game. Instead, we explore the game *Between* for its potential as a transformative medium to soothe the fear of death for both the designer and the players. The designer's fear of losing her mother motivated this project, and throughout the development, this fear was greatly eased. Drawing from this personal experience, we present

the thoughts and design behind *Between* and aim to further explore its transformative effect.

2 Related Work

2.1 Fear of Death

The fear of death can be categorized into many dimensions in death studies [19, 37]. In this work, we focus on two main dimensions: the fear of one's own death and the fear of losing loved ones [7].

The fear of one's own death is often tied to regrets and legacy: the fear of not completing what could have been done and the fear of leaving little value behind [5, 35]. This fear is linked to personal meaningfulness, which can be shaped by religious beliefs or how one understands death within their own life context [17, 35]. Raising life-affirming awareness and recognizing death in its biological state helps reduce this fear [11, 32]. These theories encourage us to view death as merely a phase of life and remind us to cherish the present time and relationships we have.

Regardless of the degree of fear we have toward our own end, most of us fear the death of others around us, especially the loss of loved ones [1]. This fear is also what inspired the designer to initiate this project. The fear of loss often stems from loving relationships, where love is both the cause of our fear of separation and the source of comfort, as we are grateful for the time we had with our loved ones, despite the inevitable loss [2, 13].

2.2 Death-themed Games

Death in the context of games is often far from our real-life experience, and more used as a restart mechanic to foster player learning [22, 23]. However, there is a small collection of games that explore death in its real-life context, expressing grief or reflecting on death-related topics. These games are often referred to as death-themed games or death-positive games [10, 25, 28], with perhaps the most well-known examples being *That Dragon, Cancer* [26], *Spiritfarer* [34], *The Graveyard* [33], and *A Mortician's Tale* [24].

Some of these games are explored as transformative media to heal the designers' or players' grief. *That Dragon, Cancer*, as an autobiographical game, recorded the last years of the designers' young deceased child. From the development process, the designer's sorrow was greatly eased. The game also turned out to help and connect many players with similar grief experiences [15, 30]. In Sabine Harrer's writing on *Games and Bereavement*, she organized a pregnancy loss workshop where grieving mothers created their own representations of the loss. The process received much positive feedback from the participants, who reported feeling alleviated from their pain [18]. The game *Spiritfarer* depicts a farewell journey with various distinct characters, allowing players to connect the experience to their real-life encounters. As a result, the game is explored for its potential effect in helping players cope with loss in real life [10].

While there are examples of creating art as a healing agent for grief [3, 21] and games as transformative media for players [29, 36], few have addressed the fear of death before loss. In this work, we present the creative process behind *Between* and its transformative effect in soothing the designer's fear of loss during development [16].

3 Critical Reflection

This game project began with the motivation to ease the designer's fear of losing her mother, who is her only relative in this world and has been suffering from frequent small illnesses and depression. Although there is no diagnosis of impending death, nor has the designer lost her mother yet, the fact that her only relative is in a constant fragile state deeply worries the young designer. She has been dreading any accident that might occur and eventually turned to learning more about death and end-of-life care to comfort herself. By facing her fear directly and exploring the meaning of death, she began to integrate these feelings with her creative background and initiated the production of the game *Between* in 2022.

The game aims to connect with and comfort individuals sharing similar fears—those who may not have experienced a close loss in their lives yet but are beginning to worry about the potential death of themselves or their loved ones. When designing and constructing the various graves for the deceased characters in the game, the designer was guided to view death from a distance, seeing it more as an objective phase of life. She gradually understood the beauty and positive aspects of death: it marks an endpoint, making the span of life limited and thus worth cherishing. Through this process, she realized that her fear of loss was rooted in regret—the fear that her mother had not lived her life to the fullest and that they hadn't spent enough time together.

Therefore, in this game, though death is inevitable and sometimes comes unexpectedly, the focus is on remembering the meaningful moments of a past life and the love and companionship shared, rather than on intense grief or the bitterness of loss. The designer's fear is now eased as she tries to focus on the present, spend more time with her mother, and encourage her mother to enjoy life and leave fewer regrets behind. Rather than dreading the possible end, the designer overcomes her fear by finding satisfaction and appreciation in life. She lives by this philosophy and has embedded these thoughts into the various graves in the game.

4 Game Overview

The main visual elements of *Between* are based on the designer's impression of funerals—gravestones, flowers, and piano notes. Together, these elements form a spiritual graveyard in the game. The graveyard can shift between three worlds: the living, the between, and the dead (see Figure 2). In the living world, gravestones appear with names and epitaphs, similar to those in our real world. Players can read through the various lives and trigger interactions by typing the names of the deceased on their computer keyboards. Interactive graves are marked with colored petals. Some deceased spirits initiate conversations with players by lighting up letters or altering words on the epitaphs, while others reveal hidden messages or items on the back of the gravestones.

There are three main graves whose owners have unresolved wishes. After typing their names, players enter the between world, where these gravestones transform into statues that reflect the owners' past lives. Players interact with the statues, unravel their past stories and regrets, and eventually bring a meaningful item to settle their souls. Though nothing can truly be changed after death, players place the item in front of the deceased's grave to comfort



Figure 2: The same grave across three worlds: the living world (left), the between world (middle), and the death world (right).

them. When the souls are ready to let go, they ascend as flower petals into the death world.

5 Game Design

5.1 Creating an Atmospheric Experience of Death

To create a peaceful game experience around death, the designer created an atmospheric graveyard that focuses on exploring the meaningful aspects of past lives rather than invoking grief. To achieve this, the designer maintained a sense of distance between the deceased characters and the players [9, 20]: instead of depicting concrete individuals, the deceased are represented through grave-stones inscribed only with first names, symbolizing a type of life rather than a specific person. There are no human figures in the game; characters are portrayed abstractly through epitaphs, items, and flower petals. This resembles our experience of visiting graveyards in the real world and leaves an ambiguous impression, allowing players to project their own context or imagination [14, 18].

Various death and loss relationships are depicted in the game [38]: There is a grave for a young deceased girl, where her family carved her favorite pattern on the gravestone with the words, "We are glad that she ever came to this world." There is a couple's grave memorializing a loving relationship; though they had regrets about an unborn child, they carried each other through the years. There is a grave of a plant lover who enjoyed her personal life and asked the players to water her flowers... In contrast to games that depict a single detailed grief story, *Between* presents players with various yet outlined losses, encouraging them not to invest heavily in individual deaths but to reflect on the topic of death as a whole [4, 8]. This aligns with the designer's experience of coping with fear: stepping out of an intimate loss relationship and viewing death from a more detached perspective. Reflecting on death beyond grief helps us recognize the valuable things and relationships in life—the ones that will be engraved on our gravestones are the ones we should cherish now.

Similar to real life, in this game, neither regrets nor death can truly be altered. Players simply learn about the stories of past lives and bring a meaningful item to the deceased's grave as an act of mourning. Whether the spirits can actually be relieved remains uncertain, but the act serves as a comfort to the player characters, much like mourning does for us in the real world [6].

5.2 Key Designs: "Spiritual Gravestone" and Typing Melodies

One of the key designs that shaped the game *Between* is the "spiritual gravestone" in the between world. Consisting of representative items and a flower reflecting personal traits, it visually communicates the essence of a past life to players. The "spiritual gravestone" extends the descriptive context beyond traditional gravestones with names and epitaphs, representing the spiritual traits of the deceased—hobbies, qualities, and regrets (see Figure 3). This design reduces the reliance on narrative text and allows us to maintain a soothing, atmospheric gameplay experience without heavy reading [31].

Another key design of *Between* is the typing mechanic accompanied by piano notes. In the game, players type the deceased's names on their computer keyboard to initiate interaction with the gravestones. This interaction is embedded with the idea that players are calling the deceased's names in melodies. As they type, the corresponding letter on the gravestone lights up and emits a piano note. Stringed together, the name flows into a melody that aligns with the impression of the deceased's story. Through this interaction, the designer aims to draw players away from the physical gaming environment, transforming their computer keyboard into a piano keyboard with which they converse with the spirits through melodies [27].

The typing mechanic also turned out to be more accessible to audiences beyond deep gamers, as it resembles our daily use of computers. During development, the designer invited friends and family to test the game. With no experience in gameplay, her mother struggled with WASD movement, even with the designer's instructions, but the typing part went smoothly. Another friend, who had some gaming experience, had no issue with movement and expressed amazement at the typing interaction: "It's not often seen in games, and it felt surprisingly rewarding when I saw the letters light up as I typed". The designer kept the typing mechanics and other interactions relatively simple to accommodate audiences who are drawn to the topic but may be unfamiliar with gaming controls or kinetic challenges [18].

6 Conclusion and Future Work

In this work, we examine the game *Between* as a transformative medium to ease the fear of death. We present the design process, incorporating the personal experience of the designer and first author, whose fear of loss was greatly alleviated through its development.

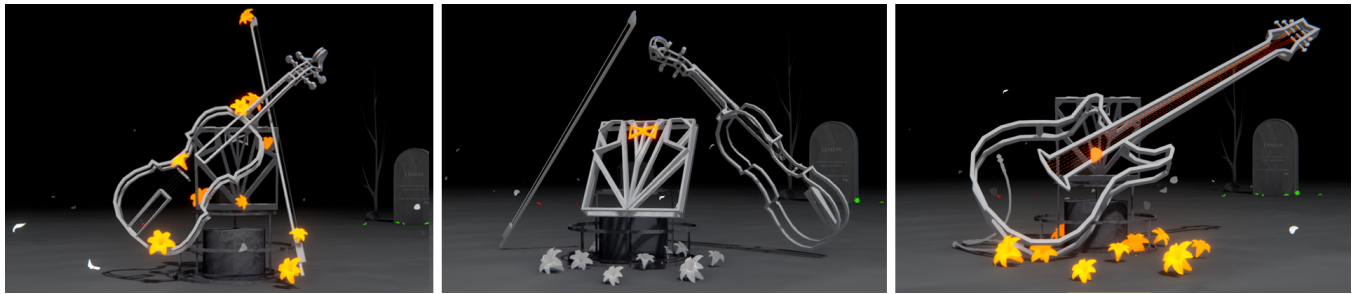


Figure 3: The 'spiritual gravestone' of Anson, the violinist, with the regret of a rock band in his youth.

With existing death-themed games mainly depicting grief after loss, our game *Between* aims to ease the fear of death before loss. The game is designed to comfort the designer in her fear of losing her mother and to connect with individuals who share a similar fear. These individuals may not have experienced a close loss in their lives yet but are beginning to worry about the potential death of themselves or their loved ones. By creating a soothing, atmospheric graveyard, the game introduces players to various loss stories. Though death is inevitable in this game, the focus is on remembering the meaningful moments of past lives and the love and companionship shared, rather than invoking grief.

With the main part of the game development complete, our next step is to conduct a qualitative test to analyze the game's transformative effect on players. Additionally, the designer plans to continue development by adding a customizable section in the graveyard where players can leave a gravestone of their own for other visitors to interact with. The gravestones can memorialize a loss in real life, a past phase of self, or a beloved item [12]. This is expected to further enhance the game's engagement and transformative effect.

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